BY ORDER OF THE SECRETARY OF THE AIR FORCE

DEPARTMENT OF THE AIR FORCE POLICY DIRECTIVE 36-40

23 APRIL 2026

Personnel

LANGUAGE, REGIONAL EXPERTISE, AND CULTURE PROGRAM

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This directive implements Department of Defense Directive (DoDD) 5160.41E, *Defense Language, Regional Expertise, and Culture (LREC) Program;* Department of Defense Instruction (DoDI) 5160.70, *Management of the Defense Language, Regional Expertise, and Culture (LREC) Program*; DoDI 5160.71, *DoD Language Testing Program*; DoDI 1340.27, *Military Foreign Language Skill Proficiency Bonuses*; and DoDI 3902.02, *Special Operations Forces Foreign Language, Regional Expertise, and Culture Policy*. This publication establishes policy for developing language, regional expertise, and culture (LREC) capabilities under the direction of the Air Force Deputy Chief of Staff, Manpower, Personnel and Services (AF/A1). This publication applies to Department of the Air Force (DAF) civilian employees and uniformed members of the Regular Air Force (RegAF), United States Space Force (USSF), Air Force Reserve (AFR), and Air National Guard (ANG). This publication may not be supplemented. This policy directive was developed in coordination with the Chief of Air Force Reserve (AF/RE), the Director, Air National Guard, acting as the 2ltr for the National Guard Bureau (NGB/CF), and the Space Force Deputy Chief of Space Operations for Personnel (SF/S1). AF/A1 establishes policy for identifying, developing, sustaining, and utilizing LREC capabilities. Ensure all records generated as a result of processes prescribed in this publication adhere to Air Force Instruction (AFI) 33-322, *Records Management and Information Governance Program*, and are disposed in accordance with the Air Force Records Disposition Schedule, which is located in the Air Force Records Information Management System. Refer recommended changes and questions about this publication to the office of primary responsibility (OPR) using the DAF Form 847, *Recommendation for Change of Publication*; route DAF Forms 847 from the field through the appropriate functional chain of command.

SUMMARY OF CHANGES

This document has been revised and should be completely reviewed. This revision updates the appropriate organizations, responsibilities, and policies applicable to the DAF LREC Program.

1. Overview. This publication establishes policy, roles, and responsibilities for creating and sustaining the LREC capabilities critical for the DAF to successfully execute warfighting missions, security cooperation engagements, peacetime operations, and to build partner capacity

2. It is policy that the Department of the Air Force will:

2.1. Optimize the accession, development, sustainment, enhancement, and employment of foreign language, regional expertise, and cultural capabilities critical to the Department's functions, and establish roles and responsibilities for LREC stakeholders across the DAF to ensure that Airmen and Guardians with critical LREC skills and competencies are available to meet validated and prioritized mission requirements that support global operational readiness.

2.2. Maintain a comprehensive LREC program to develop, sustain, and enhance such capabilities across the Total Force according to validated and prioritized mission requirements.

2.3. Execute the Department of Defense (DoD) English Language Training Program to meet DoD and international military partners' English language training requirements in order to advance National Defense Strategy and DoD security cooperation goals.

3. Roles and Responsibilities.

3.1. **The Assistant Secretary of the Air Force, for Manpower and Reserve Affairs (SAF/MR) will:**

3.1.1. Provide guidance, direction, and oversight for both the DAF LREC Program and the DoD English Language Training Program; conducts these activities for all matters pertaining to the formulation, review, and execution of plans, policies, programs, and budgets.

3.1.2. Designate, in writing, a general officer or civilian equivalent to serve as the DAF Senior Language Authority (SLA) and to execute, on behalf of the Secretary of the Air Force, the DoD Executive Agent (EA) responsibilities and authorities for the Defense Language Institute English Language Center (DLIELC).

3.1.3. Report the status of language (foreign and English), regional expertise, and culture programs to the Office of the Secretary of Defense, as required.

3.2. **The Assistant Secretary of the Air Force for Financial Management and Comptroller (SAF/FM):** Will coordinate with the AF/A1 and SF/S1 to submit the Foreign Language Proficiency Bonus budget estimates for Military Personnel Program Objective Memorandum/Program Budget Review build.

3.3. **The Deputy Under Secretary of the Air Force for International Affairs (SAF/IA)** will oversee LREC force development, sustainment, and manpower requirements for Foreign Area Officers and other Total Force International Affairs Specialists, as appropriate, in coordination with the DAF SLA and Air Education and Training Command, as well as AF/RE and NGB/CF for the Air Reserve Components (ARC).

3.4. **The Director of Public Affairs (SAF/PA):** Will serve as the office of primary responsibility for supporting LREC strategic communication internal and external to the DAF.

3.5. **The Deputy Chief of Staff of the Air Force for Manpower, Personnel, and Services (AF/A1) will:**

3.5.1. Oversee the development and implementation of a DAF LREC strategy, which directly supports Air Force strategic guidance.

3.5.2. Appoint the Director of Force Development (AF/A1D) as the SLA whose responsibilities include DoD EA duties for DLIELC pursuant to Headquarters Air Force Mission Directive (HAFMD) 1-32, *Deputy Chief of Staff of the Air Force Manpower, Personnel, and Services*.

3.5.3. Provide oversight of the DLIELC's execution of the DoD English Language Training Program in accordance with DoDI 5160.70.

3.5.4. Provide oversight to maintain, monitor, and report a separate program element for the Air Force Culture and Language Center and the DLIELC.

3.5.5. Provide oversight as the office of primary responsibility for the Joint Capabilities Based Requirements Identification Process for LREC capabilities as described in Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff Instruction (CJCSI) 3126.01C, *Language, Regional Expertise (LREC), and Culture Capability Identification, Planning, and Sourcing.*

3.5.6. Oversee the implementation of force development strategies and policies to recruit, develop, and retain Air Force personnel with LREC capabilities.

3.5.7. Provide oversight to track and advise on language-designated positions; LREC capabilities; and utilization as required by DoD policy.

3.5.8. Provide oversight to establish and maintain coordination between the Air Force Personnel Center and Air Reserve Personnel Center to update and maintain Total Force personnel record systems to enable coding of LREC related information.

3.6. **The Deputy Chief of Space Operations for Personnel (SF/S1) will:**

3.6.1. Collaborate with AF/A1 to implement policy for Space Force LREC programs.

3.6.2. Serve as the focal point for implementation of policies, plans, programs, and guidance for Space Force LREC force development initiatives, skills tracking, and utilization.

3.6.3. Provide training resources for LREC programs based on valid and prioritized Space Force requirements.

3.6.4. Design processes to support utilization of language-capable Guardians.

3.6.5. Coordinate and execute Foreign Language Proficiency Bonus policy for Guardians.

3.7. **The Director, of the Air National Guard (NGB/CF), acting as the 2ltr for the National Guard Bureau:** Will coordinate with AF/A1 to establish and implement plans, programs, and guidance for LREC force development initiatives, skills tracking, and utilization.

3.8. **The Chief of Air Force Reserve (AF/RE), will:**

3.8.1. Coordinate with AF/A1 to establish and implement plans, programs and guidance for LREC force development initiatives, skills tracking, and utilization.

3.8.2. Prioritize the accession, development, sustainment, and utilization of LREC skills in support of Air Force requirements.

3.8.3. Establish a standardized process for assigning language-qualified personnel to language-designated positions and supervise the implementation of policy for these assignments.

3.9. **The Deputy Chief of Staff of the Air Force for Intelligence, Surveillance, Reconnaissance, and Cyber Effects Operations (AF/A2/6), will:**

3.9.1. Designate in writing, and in coordination with the DAF SLA, a general officer or civilian equivalent to serve as the Deputy DAF SLA.

3.9.2. Oversee LREC force development and sustainment requirements for Air Force Cryptologic Language Analysts in coordination with AF/A1.

3.10. **The Deputy Chief of Staff of the Air Force for Operations (AF/A3**): Will provide policy and oversight to organize, train, and equip Air Advisors with LREC capabilities required to meet operational requirements including security cooperation and irregular warfare.

3.11. **The Deputy Chief of Staff of the Air Force for Logistics, Engineering and Force Protection (AF/A4):** Will serve as an office of coordinating responsibility to identify requirements and leverage opportunities to provide pre-deployment LREC training, education, and experiences to Total Force Civil Engineer and Security Forces personnel in support of theater campaign plans.

3.12. **The Surgeon General of the Air Force (AF/SG):** Will serve as the office of primary responsibility to organize, train, equip, and utilize International Health Specialists with LREC capabilities that support DAF, joint, and DoD requirements.

3.13. **The Commander, Air Education and Training Command, will:**

3.13.1. Establish and maintain frameworks to prioritize resources for the 637th Training Group and the Air Force Culture and Language Center ensuring the development and sustainment of LREC capabilities to achieve global operational readiness.

3.13.2. Consolidate and submit language training requirements for the Defense Language Institutes, prioritize resources, and ensure culture-specific and language pre-deployment training programs prepare Airmen for operational and regional challenges.

3.14. **The Commander, Air Force Reserve Officer Training Corps, will:**

3.14.1. Develop and implement scholarship programs to increase enrollment in regional studies and language training for regions of strategic importance to the DoD.

3.14.2. Ensure programs are in place to track Reserve Officer Training Corps cadet participation in DAF and DoD sponsored language programs (e.g., Language Enabled Airman Program, Project Global Officer, Language Flagship Programs).

3.15. **The Commander, Air Force Personnel Center, will:**

3.15.1. Provide oversight and guidance to ensure the proper execution of language testing (e.g., Defense Language Proficiency Test, Oral Proficiency Interview, and Defense Language Aptitude Battery) and the Foreign Language Proficiency Bonus Program.

3.15.2. Oversee personnel data system change requests to ensure proper coding of LREC skills/certifications.

TROY E. MEINK
Secretary of the Air Force

Attachment 1

GLOSSARY OF REFERENCES AND SUPPORTING INFORMATION

References

DoDD 5160.41E, *Defense Language, Regional Expertise, and Culture (LREC) Program,* August 21, 2015

DoDI 1340.27, *Military Foreign Language Skill Proficiency Bonuses,* August 17, 2022

DoDI 3902.02, *Special Operations Forces Foreign Language, Regional Expertise, and Culture Policy*, August 17, 2023

DoDI 5160.70, *Management of the Defense Language, Regional Expertise and Culture (LREC) Program,* December 30, 2016

DoDI 5160.71, *DoD Language Testing Program,* June 30, 2022

CJCSI 3126.01C, *Language, Regional Expertise, and Culture Capability Identification, Planning, and Sourcing*, March 8, 2023

HAFMD 1-32, *Deputy Chief of Staff of the Air Force Manpower, Personnel, and Services,* September 13, 2019

DAFPD 36-26, *Total Force Development and Management*, January 18, 2024

AFI 33-322, *Records Management and Information Governance Program*, March 23, 2020

Prescribed Forms

None

Adopted Forms

DAF Form 847, *Recommendation for Change of Publication*

Abbreviations and Acronyms

AFI—Air Force Instruction

AFR—Air Force Reserve

ANG—Air National Guard

CJCSI—Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff Instruction

DAFPD—Department of the Air Force Policy Directive

DLIELC—Defense Language Institute English Language Center

DoD—Department of Defense

DoDD—Department of Defense Directive

DoDI—Department of Defense Instruction

EA—Executive Agent

HAFMD—Headquarters Air Force Mission Directive

LREC—Language, Regional Expertise, and Culture

SLA—Senior Language Authority

RegAF—Regular Air Force

USSF—United States Space Force

Office Symbols

AF/A1—Deputy Chief of Staff of the Air Force for Manpower, Personnel, and Services

AF/A1D—Directorate of Force Development

AF/A2/6—Deputy Chief of Staff of the Air Force for Intelligence, Surveillance, and Reconnaissance and Cyber Effects Operations

AF/A3—Deputy Chief of Staff of the Air Force for Operations

AF/A4—Deputy Chief of Staff of the Air Force for Logistics, Engineering, and Force Protection

AF/RE—Chief of Air Force Reserve

AF/SG—Surgeon General of the Air Force

NGB/CF—Director of the Air National Guard

SAF/FM—Assistant Secretary of the Air Force for Financial Management and Comptroller

SAF/IA—Deputy Under Secretary of the Air Force for International Affairs

SAF/MR—Assistant Secretary of the Air Force for Manpower and Reserve Affairs

SAF/PA—Director of Public Affairs

SF/S1—Deputy Chief of Space Operations for Personnel

Terms

Competencies—A combination of knowledge, skills, abilities, and other characteristics manifesting in observable and measurable pattern of behaviors required for mission success.

Development—A process of learning personal and professional advancement or growth; acquiring or enhancing attitudes, cognition, and skills.

Total Force (TF)—Includes all Airmen and Guardians (Regular Air Force, Air Force Reserve, Air National Guard, United States Space Force, and DAF civilians).

SLA—A designated senior leader (GO/SES or equivalent) serves as the Strategic Language Advisor (SLA), representing their organization's interests within the Defense LREC Program. The SLA advises component leadership on LREC capability requirements, participates in the Defense Language Steering Committee, and is responsible for developing, resourcing, and executing their organization's LREC strategic plan.